WIKIPEDIA
The Free Encyclopedia

Kamakshi Amman Temple

The **Kamakshi Amman Temple**, also known as **Kamakoti Nayaki Kovil**, is a Hindu temple dedicated to the goddess Kamakshi, one of the highest form of Parvati. She is the highest aspect Adi Parashakti, the supreme goddess in Shaktism. The temple is located in the historic city of Kanchipuram, near Chennai, India.

It may have been founded in the 5th-8th century CE by the Pallava kings,[1] whose capital was in Kanchipuram. It may also have been built by the Cholas in the 14th century,[2] and legend also says it was built as recent as 1783.[3]

The temple is one of the most important centers of Shaktism in the state of Tamil Nadu. The temple is dedicated mainly to Kamakshi, but also has a shrine for Vishnu, in his form of Varaha.[web 1] Kamakshi is worshipped in the shrine in five forms.

The temple is also the center for the Kanchi Kamakoti Peetham.

Kamakshi Amman Temple

Main gopuram (entrance tower) to the temple

Religion	
Affiliation	Hinduism
District	Kanchipuram district
Deity	Kamakshi
Location	
Location	Kanchipuram Town
State	Tamil Nadu
Country	India

Location in Tamil Nadu

History

The temple may have been founded by the Pallava kings in the 5th-8th century,[1] whose capital was in Kanchipuram. The temple is glorified by the 6th-9th century *Vaishnavite Alvars* (Tamil saint poets) in the Naalayira Divya Prabandham (compiled 9th century). It was modified in the fourteenth and seventeenth century.[4] According to Babu, it was built by the Chola's in the 14th century.[2]

Koskoff refers to a legend about the golden statue of Kamakshi. According to this legend, after the fall of the Vijayanagar Empire in 1565 the statue had been carried throughout South India by attendants, seeking a permanent temple. From 1739 to 1781 it was enshrined in the Tiruvarur temple, and in 1783 the Kamakshi Amman temple was built for the idol.[3]

Shaktism

Sri Kamakshi Amman Temple, along with the goddesses Meenakshi at Madurai, Neelayadakshi of Nagapattinam and either Vishalakshi at Varanasi or Akhilandeshwari at Thiruvanaikovil, is one of the most important centers of Shaktism in the state of Tamil Nadu. The Sri Kamakshi Amman Temple is dedicated to the goddess Kamakshi, one of the form of Parvati and the highest aspect of Adi Parashakti, she is the mighty goddess in Shaktism. Kamakshi is praised as 'Sri Mata' (respected mother) as the first name in the Lalitha Sahasranama. This temple is also one of the 18 main Shakta pithas.

Kamakshi Amman Temple (Tamil Nadu)

Coordinates	12.840684°N 79.703238°E
Architecture	
Type	Dravidian architecture

Architecture

The temple occupies an area of 5 acres (2.0 ha). The sanctum houses the image of Kamakshi in a seated posture and is flanked by the trinity of Shiva, Vishnu, and Brahma. There are smaller shrines of Bangaru (Golden) Kamakshi, Adi Shankara and Saraswati around the sanctum.[5]

The temple is maintained and administered by the Hindu Religious and Charitable Endowments Department of the Government of Tamil Nadu.[6]

Kamakshi-shrine

Goddess Kamakshi is worshipped in the shrine in five forms:

A painting of Goddess Kamakshi in the sanctum

1. **Sri Kamakshi Para Bhattarika** – Kamakshi is the main deity of the temple. The idol is seated in the center of the inner sanctum of the shrine from the Gayatri Mandapa. According to the *Kamakshi Rahasya*, this hall was built by the celestials with the four walls representing the four Vedas and the twenty-four pillars representing the twenty-four syllables of the Gayatri Mantra. The idol, which forms the inner core of the Gayatri Hall, is enshrined at the center of the hall as Kamakshi. She is seated on a throne made from the five Brahmas and sports in her four hands a noose, goad, a sugarcane bow, and flower arrow. The idol is depicted seated in the *Padmasana* (Lotus pose) and faces south-east. The idol of Kamakshi has been described as representing her three forms: *Sthula* (symbolizing Dhyana and Yoga), *Sukshma* (symbolizing Mantra and Yantra), and *Karana* or *Vasanatmaka*. In front of the idol is a Sri Yantra, which according to the temple history was placed there by Adi Shankaracharya.[1]
2. **Tapa Kamakshi** – This form of Kamakshi can be seen to the right of the main idol and close to the Bila gate. Legend says that Parvati was separated from Shiva, and appeared first as Annapurneshwari in

either Varanasi or Horanadu and then following the advice of sage Katyayana, moved to Kanchipuram to worship Shiva as Ekambareswara under the mango tree near the Vegavati river and married him. Goddess Kamakshi is depicted as a yogini in a balancing yoga pose in this idol.

3. **Anjana Kamakshi** – Also known as Arupa Lakshmi (formless Lakshmi), her shrine is situated to the left of the main idol, facing the north and in front of the *Saubhagya Ganapati* shrine. According to legend, Lakshmi, due to a curse, is said to have performed penance on her husband Vishnu's insistence to regain her lost beauty in this place and, due to the incident, a Lakshmi shrine was built and offerings of kumkuma are offered to her here before being accepted by the devotees. While she represents Lakshmi in her form as *Lakshmi Bija*, she represents Kamakshi in the form of *Kamakalakshara* which is inherent in the Lakshmi shrine.
4. **Swarna Kamakshi** – The shrine of this deity, also known as Bangaru Kamakshi in Telugu, is situated in the second enclosure. It is said that this form was created by Kamakshi herself, from her third eye to serve as the consort of Shiva as Ekambareswara. After marrying Shiva, she was known as Goddess Elavarkuzhali. The original idol that appeared is seen today in Thanjavur. The golden idol was taken to Thanjavur by a man named Kamakshi Dasar, in the wake of Muslim invasions. The current idol is made of panchaloha, an alloy of 5 metals.
5. **Utsava Kamakshi** – The shrine of Utsava Kamakshi, the idol which is brought out during processions, is located in the second enclosure. The idol is accompanied on either side by idols of Saraswati and Lakshmi. While the gods and goddesses are generally accompanied by their consorts in most cases, on account of Kamakshi being powerful than Shiva, there is no shrine for Shiva here. Tripura Sundari, who appeared from the fire for the destruction of Bhandasura, was presented to the world by Brahma with the name Kamakshi. Thus, *Kamakshi* is the special epithet of the goddess. As she brings joy to the mind of Shiva alias Kameshwara, she is referred to as *Kameshwari*.

Bangaru Kamakshi in Thanjavur

Utsava Kamakshi

Durvasa

In front of the main shrine, is the shrine of Durvasa, considered to be an avatar of Shiva. There are thirty-two chief assistants of the goddess eg. Surya, Chandra, Kubera, etc. Among these, Kamadeva, Lopamudra and Durvasa are the chief assistants.

Durvasa represents the sattva power of the goddess, used to protect and correct her devotees, and thus her limitless power and grace. It is Durvasa who is believed to have established the shrine by consecrating a Sri Yantra in front of the idol. He composed the *Lalita Stavaratna*, also called the *Arya Dwishati*, describing Manidvipa, the abode of Kamakshi. He also composed the *Tripura Mahimna Stotra*, a complete shastra in itself, and also the *Para Shambho Mahima Stotra*. Due to a curse by Saraswati, he was born as a deaf and mute man and was graced by Kamakshi with *Anugraha Diksha*, relieving a part of his curse.

Tirukkalvanur Divya Desam (Vishnu)

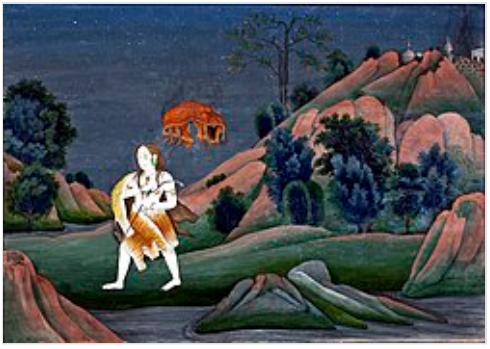
The temple also houses a shrine for Vishnu in the form of Varaha Perumal. The Tirukkalvanur Divya Desam is one of the *108 Divya Desams* (Vishnu and Lakshmi temples that are mentioned in the works of the Alvars).[web 1] The original temple was a little further from the Kamakshi temple; due to the ruined state of the old shrine, the deity is now placed inside the Kamakshi temple, in the belief that Vishnu is the brother of Kamakshi.[7]

A shrine dedicated to Hayagriva, an avatar of Vishnu and the sage Agastya can be seen in the third enclosure of the temple, at the location where Agastya learned the *Lalita Sahasranamam* from Hayagriva.[8]

Kamakshi Amman Temple with the golden overlay over its sanctum.

Related sacred history of the place

Shakta pitha



Shiva carrying the burnt corpse of Sati.

The ancient story of Daksha yajna and Sati's self-immolation is the main theme in the origin of Shakta pithas.[9] Shakta pithas are the divine temples of Adi Parashakti. The cause of the presence of the goddess is due to the falling of body parts of the corpse of Sati, Shiva's first wife. The navel part of Sati's body is believed to have fallen here in Kanchipuram, giving the name *Nabhi Peetham* or *Odhyana Peetham*. There are 51 Shakta pithas linked to the 51 alphabets in Sanskrit, out of which 18 are the most visited.[10]

Tripura Sundari

According to legend, Tripura Sundari settled here after killing a demon. Tantric texts such as Tripura Rahasya, Bahvrucha Upanishad, as well as Puranas such Brahmanda Purana and Markandeya Purana discuss how Tripura Sundari resides in Kanchipuram.[5]

Bhandasura

According to ancient scriptures, the gods were tormented by the demon Bhandasura, and performed penance to appease the goddess Adi Parashakti in the form of parrots, perching on champaka trees at the temple, since parrots always perch on the right hand of the goddesses Meenakshi and Kamakshi. Pleased with their penance, the goddess is said to have appeared through the *Bila* gate and killed Bhandasura. The Bila gate leading to the *Bilakasha* tree can be seen today in front of the Tapa Kamakshi shrine inside the sanctum.

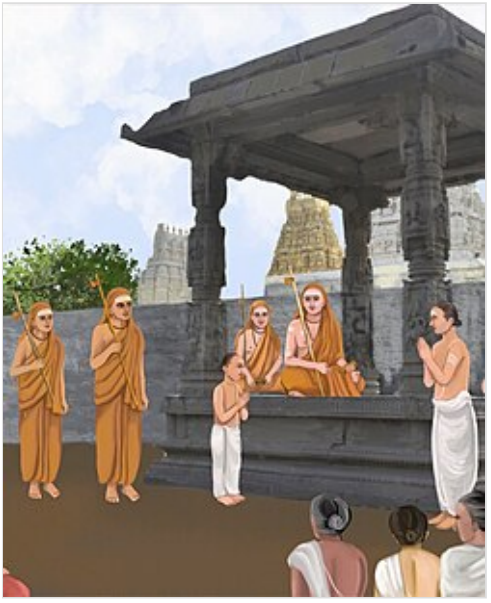
Shiva

It is said that Shiva, the inseparable husband of Shakti worshipped the goddess in the four yugas assuming the forms of the sages Krodha Bhattaraka in the Satya Yuga, Parashurama in the Treta Yuga, Dhaumya in the Dwapara Yuga, and Adi Shankara in the Kali Yuga.

It is also said that Shiva assumed the form of Durvasa on her emergence from the tree and first worshipped her by chanting the Sri Vidya Tantra and consecrating a huge structure of the Sri Yantra in a yoni shaped trough, in-front of the Kamakshi idol. Durvasa is thus the traditional teacher of Sri Vidya and foremost Gurus of the Sri Vidhya Parampara.

Adi Shankara

Adi Shankara is credited for consecrating the current Sri chakra Yantram in front of kamakshi ambal sculpture. The deities (vashinyadi vagdevadas) who composed the *Lalita Sahasranama* can be seen around the Sri chakraYantra in the same positions as depicted in Manidvipa, the abode of Kamakshi.



Jagadguru Adi Shankaracharya

Temple rituals and festivals

Four worship services are offered each day. Every day the temple rituals start with the Gau Pooja and Gaja Pooja. There is a separate shed with elephants, which performs pooja to the deity by trumpeting every day early morning at 5 AM.

The annual festival falls in Spring, in the Tamil month of Masi, which runs from mid-February to mid-March. During this Mahotsavam, the most important day to be celebrated is Maasi Pooram, which is the Avirbhava dhina of Lalitha Maha Tripura Sundari in Kanchi. Other than that, the chariot festival (Ther) and float festival, (Theppam) are held.[10] Other festivals include Navaratri, Aadi and Aippasi Pooram, Sankara Jayanthi and Vasanta Utsavam in the Tamil month of Vaikasi. All Fridays are considered sacred, though the Fridays in the Tamil months of Adi (mid-July to mid-August) and Thai (mid-January to mid-February) are celebrated.

Kanchi Kamakoti Peetham

The temple is also the center for the Kanchi Kamakoti Peetham . The Kanchi Kamakoti Peetham is deeply connected to the Sri Kamakshi Temple in Kanchipuram. The Jagadguru Shankaracharya Swamigal of the Peetham serves as the hereditary trustee of the Kamakshi Ambal Devasthanam, ensuring the temple's rituals and festivals are conducted according to ancient traditions and the instructions of the Shankaracharya. The temple's deity, Kamakshi, is revered as a major center of Shaktism, and the Peetham plays a significant role in its upkeep and management.

References

1. Pokhriyal (2023).
2. Babu (2020), p. 25.
3. Koskoff (2008), p. 991-992.
4. NN (2011).
5. Diwakar, Macherla (2011). *Temples of South India* (1st ed.). Chennai: Techno Book House. p. 140. ISBN 978-93-83440-34-4.
6. "Thirukoil - Temple list of Tamil Nadu" (https://web.archive.org/web/20201009010850/https://tnhrce.gov.in/resources/docs/temple_list.pdf) (PDF). Hindu Religious & Charitable Endowments Department, Government of Tamil Nadu. p. 244. Archived from the original (https://tnhrce.gov.in/resources/docs/temple_list.pdf) (PDF) on 9 October 2020. Retrieved 13 November 2021.
7. *South Indian shrines: illustrated* P.539.P. V. Jagadisa Ayyar
8. V., Meena (1974). *Temples in South India* (1st ed.). Kanniyakumari: Harikumar Arts. p. 41.
9. "Kottiyoor Devaswam Temple Administration Portal" (https://kottiyoordevaswom.com/). Kottiyoor Devaswam. Retrieved 20 July 2013.
10. Harshananda, Swami (2012). *Hindu Pilgrimage Centres* (second ed.). Bangalore: Ramakrishna Math. p. 61. ISBN 978-81-7907-053-6.

Sources

Printed sources

- Babu, Ganesh (2020). *Tourism Guide. Tamilnadu and Pondicherry*. Archers & Elevators Publishing House.
- Koskoff, Ellen, ed. (2008). "Syama Sastri". *The Concise Garland Encyclopedia of World Music. Volume 2. The Middle East, South Asia, East Asia, Southeast Asia*. Routledge.
- NN (2011). *Rough Guide to India*. Rough Guides UK.
- Pokhriyal, Ramesh (2023). *Famous Temples in Tamil Nadu*. Diamond Pocket Books.

Web-sources

1. templenet.com, Abodes of Vishnu - Tirukkalvanoor (http://www.templenet.com/Tamilnadu/df054.html)

External links

- Temple Information Website (https://www.kanchikamakshi.org/)
- Templenet entry for temple (http://www.templenet.com/Tamilnadu/kamakshi.html)
- Photos of Kamakshi temple of Kanchipuram, 1280x960 (https://sss.vn.ua/india/tamilnadu/kanchipuram/kamakshi_en.htm)

Retrieved from "https://en.wikipedia.org/w/index.php?title=Kamakshi_Amman_Temple&oldid=1320583478"